# Learning to Swim

## By Ann Turner

We are packing the car
to go to the summerhouse
everything is in bits and pieces.
Nicky and I are fighting
over the seat but I
am not moving,
I am sitting on my pink
swimming ring that Daddy says
I don't need anymore
because I am big enough,
old enough,
and fast enough
to swim on my own.

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## INTRODUCTION

*Summer --- an innocent time when little girls should be joyfully picking blueberries with their mothers, playing with their brothers, and learning to swim with their fathers. And those memories are there, but there are other memories too . . . memories of drowning, secrets, fear and finally . . . telling Learning to Swim by Ann Turner*

Nicky and I climb down
the knobby path to Dresser's Pond.
Daddy holds my hand.
"Don't be afraid."
My pink swimming ring
on the grass
used to keep
the black water below.
Now I cannot see my toes
and flail my arms,
churn the water to a froth,
but the water tugs at me
willing me to go under.
Daddy shouts again, "You can do it!"

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I kick my feet,
suck in a breath,
and for a moment,
I sail above
the drowned leaves!
We are running races
in the meadow
with the kids from down
the street -- Kevin, Lonny, Angie –
legs pumping,
hands swinging,
my feet blur
as I pull ahead of
everyone
my breath works
my heart works
my legs work
and I shout when I win.

Kevin, Lonny, and Angie all live
in a little green house

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with a fat mother,
hair greasy in her face,
frying donuts,
and their father is thin
and shabby with an open mouth
shouting
we are runmng away
somehow I am always It
looking for a place to hide
from their feet and their hot
breath going by.

"I'll read to you,"
Kevin whispers,
"a secret time for us
and never, ever tell."
He takes my hand
and leads me up the stairs.
But in my hot, yellow room
the book falls to the floor
and he jams his hands

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inside of me
and takes out his private parts
that I didn't ever know
could look so huge and strange,
telling me to touch him
in a hard, breathless voice,
and I didn't even know
I could say
no.

I tried to swim
today
thrashing in the water
but clouds covered the
sun  there was no pink
ring to keep me safe,
and I could not keep my head
above water.
Daddy pulled me out,
thumped my back,
and said, "Next 'time,

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Annie, next time."

It is happening again
your hand is out
holding mine
the book is in your other
hand
we are disappearing
up the stairs
and Peter waves to me
from his playpen.
He can't talk so he
can't tell
(I promised not to!)
and after it is all over
I whisper in his
baby ear
and push my face
into the couch cushions
so no one can see.

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I am holding it all
inside like when I am sick
and running to find a bathroom
the words are crowding behind
my lips bursting to get out
so bad my lips ache
but I can't. You said no
not ever not nohow
and you bunched your fist
in my face.
But my dolls know,
Jenny, Amanda, and Fuchsia.
At night
I tell them what you did
and they are sad for me
with their wide-open eyes
and surprised mouths.

I tried to swim
today
thrashing in the water

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but the clouds covered the
sun  there was no pink
ring to keep me safe,
and I could not keep my head
above water.
Daddy pulled me out,
thumped my back,
and said, "Next time,
Annie, next time."

I thought a secret was
a cookie hidden in a hand,
like the one you hold now
as you lead me up the stairs.
My feet drag
they know what is waiting
at the top
but I am too small
to say no
only my body is so
slow  it is waiting

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for someone to notice
I am going away.

"Come on, Annie,
What's wrong?"
Daddy holds out his hand
it is not like the other
hand
taking me away but
still I will not go in.
The water looks gloomy
and dark with shadows
I will be swallowed up
the drowned leaves
will cover my mouth.
I ask for my ring back
and sit
on the grass.

I am scribbling
with a crayon

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on a crinkly piece
of paper
you have a rain of fire
on your head
your arms are
stumps
your feet
burned off
when Mother asks,
"What is it, Annie?"
words flyaway
and she looks at me
with worried eyes.

She asked me today,
"What book does Kevin read
up in your room?"
My eyes blinked,
my tongue stuck
to the top of my mouth
on the words I'd been waiting

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to say
each one hurt
like a splinter
yanked out
and before I was done
she grabbed me up and we cried
and cried
until
there were no more
words to tell.

Mother is jamming on
her walking shoes,
jerking the laces tight,
"Annie, stay here.
Kevin will *never* hurt you
again."
She slams out the
door but I am afraid
of the green house
the lips the hands and him.

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I wait on the porch
watching
my stomach clenches in
until I see the top of her head
getting bigger, rounder
then all of her running up the drive
her short hair flying,
and when she holds me
her skin burns.

Daddy took my hands
today, swinging me high
over the hurting plants
in Grandma's rock garden
he settled me on his knee
his safe smell was all
around
and he told me he knew
that he was so sorry he would
drink up every bit of water in
Dresser's Pond if that would

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make it all unhappen
it can't
every bit of water
is in my eyes
I sit on his warm lap
and put my head
under his chin.

Grandpa left me a letter
in the old knothole
by the stone pillars.
I reached in and pulled out
the note covered with blue
words:
"You are my fairy girl
with brown curls
and impish smile
and a laugh like a cloud."
For a moment
I felt like one - airy,
light as mist,

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floating up the drive.

Daddy held my hand
as we scrambled down
the path to Dresser's Pond.
We waded in together,
and I thought of white, bony
things I could not see,
of a lake octopus waiting
to sucker its tentacles
around my skinny legs.
Daddy said,
"You are learning to swim,"
and I let go of his hand.
"I am learning to swim,"
I chanted
and when the bottom
fell away,
I bobbed on top,
my face like a white flower
before me.

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*Listen.*

*Telling is what matters,*

*You have to catch*

*the words you're been hiding*

*inside or keeping in a dark*

*hurting ball in the middle*

*of your stomach that make you*

*sick*

*but pulling the words up*

*and out, spilling them*

*across the floor, the table,*

*dropping them into someone's*

*surprised face that*

*is what matters*

*and after this time*

*and the next one day*

*you will fee! so*

*light and airy*

*your stomach will*

*uncoil*

*your face*

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*unclench*

*and you will fee!*

*Like yourself*

*again.*

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## SOURCE INFORMATION

***Author: Ann Turner***
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## AWARD HISTORY

***2003 National Qualifier***
***2004 National Qualifier***
***2008 National Qualifier***
***2009 National Qualifier***
***2010 National Qualifier***
***IL State Qualifier***
***KS State Qualifier***
***MN State Qualifier***
***S. Dakota State Finalist***